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送信者: EG Japan Research 受信日時: 2026-09-29 17:52

【メール原文】

A steady pair of hands Under Takaichi, the US-Japan relationship remains on remarkably solid footing. Much like former prime minister Abe Shinzo, who |||||

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29 Sep 2026 04:51 EDT [Discover more on the Portal](#)

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Prime Minister Takaichi Sanae has successfully maintained stable relations with Washington by forging a strong personal relationship with President Donald Trump and reinforcing the US-Japan alliance.

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Her rapport with Trump was on display when the two leaders met this month, with the meeting timed to send a message of continued solidarity to Beijing ahead of Trump's summit with President Xi Jinping.

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Takaichi's Trump playbook relies on reframing Japanese priorities as serving US interests, increasing investment in the US and in US priorities at home, and preventing irritants from affecting the broader relationship.

A steady pair of hands

Under Takaichi, the US-Japan relationship remains on remarkably solid footing. Much like former prime minister Abe Shinzo, who deftly handled Japan's relations with the US during Trump's first term, Takaichi has used flattery, genuflection, and an unwavering emphasis on maintaining the US-Japan alliance to build strong personal ties with Trump. What is often viewed to be capitulation by Takaichi—committing to invest \$550 billion in the US and brushing aside Trump's off-color jokes about Pearl Harbor—is better understood as steely-eyed determination.

For Japan, there is no alternative to its alliance with the US. Takaichi has increased outreach to other middle-power countries such as India, Vietnam, and Australia, but not at the expense of Tokyo's relationship with Washington. She understands her task clearly: support Trump's policy agenda wherever she can, minimize friction where she cannot, and build rapport with the US president at every available opportunity. She strategically uses her interactions with Trump—before this month, she last visited Washington in March—while relying on the connective tissue between the two governments to highlight Japan's contributions to advancing Trump's agenda in the interim.

Takaichi's engagement strategy with Washington is paying off. Where most US allies and partners have seen their relations with the US deteriorate since Trump took office, Japan remains an exception. Trump granted Takaichi a meeting this month in New York while turning down similar requests from dozens of other foreign leaders; the personal warmth between the two leaders was also evident, with Trump lavishing praise on Takaichi's leadership and noting her high approval ratings. Trump loves a winner,

and he takes personal credit for her historic victory in the lower house elections in February (see: [Unpacking Japan's Snap Elections](#) , 11 February 2026).

The timing of Takaichi's meeting with Trump this month was deliberate. She wanted to be the last voice that Trump heard before he welcomed Chinese President Xi Jinping to Washington the following day, hoping to shape Trump's thinking about Japan's importance to his broader Asia policy. While lasting fewer than 40 minutes, the Trump-Takaichi meeting sent an important signal of the enduring strength of US-Japan ties amid concerns that Washington's outreach to Beijing is coming at the expense of the US's alliance commitments in Asia. Similarly, a trilateral meeting of the foreign ministers of Japan, South Korea, and the US on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly was also meant to send a message of solidarity to China and North Korea.

Takaichi's Trump playbook

Other foreign leaders can draw lessons from Takaichi's deft management of the US-Japan alliance, even if their individual circumstances differ. Their countries likely face different political and economic constraints in their interactions with the US, which may limit their ability to follow aspects of her Trump playbook. Some foreign leaders, for example, may not have the political space to closely align themselves with Trump (Takaichi's approval ratings remain high and public attitudes in Japan toward the US are broadly positive); other countries likely cannot credibly commit to invest \$550 billion in the US as Japan has done; still others may lack the technological capabilities or deep historical ties to partner with the US in the same way. Nevertheless, Takaichi's approach to managing her relationship with Trump offers lessons for almost every country:

Focus on US priorities. Tokyo has consistently protected its core interests by reframing them as benefiting the US.

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For months, Japanese officials have told their US counterparts that China's restrictions on rare earth exports to Japan will negatively affect US companies that depend on Japanese suppliers. This rhetoric is now echoed by Trump and other US officials in their conversations with Beijing and have likely prevented China from increasing its economic coercion against Japan. Trump raised the issue in his summit with Xi in May and likely again at their meeting last week (see: [Beijing will maintain calibrated pressure campaign against Tokyo](#) , 20 July 2026).

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Fearing that easing restrictions against Chinese investment in the US could erode the competitiveness of Japanese firms, Tokyo has warned Washington that allowing Chinese companies to invest in the US would not benefit American workers. Tokyo claims that Japanese companies hire more local employees at their US factories than Chinese firms would—a talking point that Trump has used to justify his reluctance to allow Chinese automakers to invest in the US.

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Japan has switched from skepticism to full-throated support of US-led efforts to develop critical mineral supply chains, which remains a key priority of Takaichi's economic security agenda. In March, Japan and the US announced more than a dozen critical mineral projects worldwide. Tokyo has similarly backed Washington's proposal to introduce border-adjusted price floors for critical minerals, while ensuring that the price floors are introduced gradually and do not disrupt industry.

Speak softly and carry a big checkbook. Under Takaichi, Tokyo has leaned heavily on its financial firepower to advance the US-Japan relationship. It has pursued this strategy primarily by significantly

increasing investment in the US and by spending more on Washington's priorities in Japan.

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Japan has been notably more proactive than other US partner countries in announcing investments in the US under its \$550 billion pledge (see: Tokyo pulling ahead of Seoul on US investments , 30 July 2026). Takaichi has backed Japanese negotiators as they announced large investment projects, many with questionable financial prospects, even before final details have been resolved. She views the prospect of falling behind on Japan's investment pledge as potentially far more costly to the bilateral alliance—a lesson that Korea is belatedly learning (see: Seoul will go big on US investments to placate Washington , 16 September).

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Tokyo has already announced six projects as part of two rounds of investments, totaling \$109 billion, with a third round expected later this year. Washington is pushing Tokyo to accelerate that announcement before the midterm elections, even as the two sides try to resolve issues related to small modular reactor projects announced in March. Japan's chief negotiator has indicated that the third round will likely expand beyond the energy and infrastructure focus of the first two rounds to include semiconductors and critical minerals.

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Takaichi has also quietly agreed to US demands to increase Japan's defense spending levels without publicly committing to a quantitative target. Tokyo fears that announcing a goal such as 3.5% of GDP, up from about 2% currently, would fuel questions about Japan's fiscal outlook and trigger further demands from Trump. Later this year, Japan will announce revisions to three national security documents that will likely significantly increase defense spending over the next five years.

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Over the next three months, diplomats from the two countries will hold difficult discussions on the next Special Measures Agreement, which sets Japan's financial support for US troops stationed there. Both sides expect to reach an agreement by December, when the current agreement expires, but their positions remain far apart. Neither side will likely end up satisfied with the final agreement, but given the outsized importance of this issue to Trump, Takaichi will likely seek a face-saving way to accede to US demands for significantly more financial support.

Contain impact of inevitable irritants. Even the US-Japan relationship is not immune from low-level frictions, which Takaichi is working assiduously to keep contained. Many of those issues came up in her meeting with Trump last week, although they did not spill over into their public remarks or ruin the overall positive atmosphere.

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Tokyo is working behind the scenes to prevent US sanctions against judges on the ICC, including ICC President Akane Tomoko. Takaichi has received domestic criticism for her relatively understated response to Washington's pressure campaign against the court, but she is careful not to split with Trump on this issue publicly.

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In the Iran conflict, Japan is positioning itself as a diplomatic intermediary to Tehran, with which it has long maintained close ties. Tokyo hopes this role will reduce pressure to provide military support in the Strait of Hormuz, an issue on which Trump has largely given Tokyo a pass (unlike South Korea).

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Trump raised concerns with Takaichi over persistent weakness in the Japanese yen, which has potential spillover effects to the US economy. Takaichi has softened her resistance in recent months to raising

interest rates at home, while Tokyo has continued to coordinate with Washington on currency market intervention to support the yen.

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